toward a dualistic approach. They came to think of humans as consisting of a good immaterial soul trapped inside an evil material body. They didn't fantasise about being resurrected in the flesh. Just the opposite. Having been released by death from its abominable material prison, why would the pure soul ever want to get back in? Christians accordingly began to believe that after death the soul is liberated from the body and exists forever in an immaterial place completely beyond the physical realm – which is the standard belief among Christians today, notwithstanding what Tertullian and the Second Council of Lyon said.[34]

But Christianity couldn't completely abandon the old Jewish view that humans are embodied beings. After all, Christ appeared on earth in the flesh. His body was nailed to the cross, on which he experienced excruciating pain. For two thousand years, Christian sects therefore fought each other – sometimes with words, sometimes with swords – over the exact relations between soul and body. The fiercest arguments focused on Christ's own body. Was he material? Was he purely spiritual? Did he perhaps have a non-binary nature, being both human and divine at the same time?

The different approaches to the mind–body problem influenced how people treated their own bodies. Saints, hermits and monks made breathtaking experiments in pushing the human body to its limits. Just as Christ allowed his body to be tortured on the cross, so these 'athletes of Christ' allowed lions and bears to rip them apart while their souls rejoiced in divine ecstasy. They wore hair shirts, fasted for weeks or stood for years on a pillar – like the famous Simeon who allegedly stood for about forty years on top of a pillar near Aleppo.[35]

Other Christians took the opposite approach, believing that the body didn't matter at all. The only thing that mattered was faith. This idea was taken to extremes by Protestants like Martin Luther, who formulated the doctrine of *sola fide:* only faith. After living as a monk for about ten years, fasting and torturing his body in various ways, Luther despaired of these bodily exercises. He reasoned that no bodily self-torments could force God to redeem him. Indeed, thinking he could win his own salvation by torturing his body was the sin of pride. Luther therefore disrobed, married a former nun and told his followers that to be good Christians, the only thing they needed was to have complete faith in Christ.[36]